

User interview: Food ordering app habits and pain points

User Profile

- Checks notifications first for discount alerts before ordering
- Prefers biryani; also orders starters, rotis, and curry
- Orders 8–10 times/month (1–2/week)
- Primary apps: Swiggy and Zomato

Ordering Priorities

- Speed is top priority for afternoon/workday orders
- Price sensitivity kicks in for late-night and weekend orders
- Decision framework: final price + effort to get the food, not fee breakdown
 - Aware that advertised discounts (e.g. “₹100 off”) often deliver less (e.g. ₹80–93)

Awareness of New Apps (Only, Tying)

- Seen ads for both; considered trying but never followed through
 - Friction: wouldn't download a new app while already hungry
 - Would try if already installed; inertia is the main barrier

Pricing UI Preference

- Prefers the first/left format when shown two checkout screens
 - Wants clarity on whether discounts are applied
 - Right format useful for a tree/breakdown view, but not for final settlement

Pain Points and Switching Triggers

- Bad Zomato experience: ordered chicken curry + 2 egg puffs, received pizza + 1 egg puff
 - Zomato declined refund (claimed equal value); only sent an email, no resolution
 - Now mostly avoids Zomato
- Search and discovery is a recurring frustration

- Specific items (e.g. a particular sauce, ice cream) hard to find via current filters
 - Filters skew toward popular categories like biryani
- Would switch to a new app if:
 - Friends recommend it and find better restaurants
 - App has brand credibility and community trust
 - Even a Bangalore-only app would be considered if service quality is high

Segment 1: Student Respondent

Ordering Frequency and Preferences

- Orders food online very rarely; last order was roughly a year ago
- Strongly prefers eating outside where food is hot and freshly served
- Main reason to order online: speed and convenience, not cost savings

Pain Points with Food Delivery

- Extra charges (delivery fees, platform fees, surge limits) feel unpredictable and frustrating
- Cannot verify restaurant hygiene when ordering online
 - Ratings reflect taste only, not cleanliness
 - When eating out, can visually assess hygiene; that option disappears with delivery
- Food quality degrades in transit
 - Moisture causes packaging to become oily at the bottom
 - Food turns soft due to steam and condensation

Price vs. Delivery Speed Tradeoff

- Default preference: faster delivery over cheaper price
 - Core logic: “If it takes long time, I can go out and eat”
- Nuance: hunger level determines the tradeoff
 - Very hungry: will pay more for speed
 - Can wait: will choose the cheaper, slower option

Group Ordering Behavior

- Typically orders as a group with friends (4-5 people)
- One friend holds a Zomato Gold subscription
 - Unlocks group discounts: ~₹100 off or ~10% discount when 4-5 members join

- Always compares Swiggy and Zomato pricing before placing an order
- Time is not a major factor in group ordering decisions

Pricing UI Comparison Reaction

- Shown two apps displaying the same item from the same restaurant
- Chose App 1 without hesitation
 - Reason: “Price-wise it is less, and I know what I’m paying for”
- App 2 showed item priced at ₹160 but billed ₹272
 - ~₹100 in unexplained additional charges
 - “I can’t pay ₹100 extra for something else”
- Predicted App 1 would gain more traction overall
- Segmented the market unprompted:
 - Premium customers: prioritize time, not price
 - Students, middle-class families, frequent orderers: price is the only real driver

Awareness of Only/Ownly App

- Heard about it recently through his brother
- Has not tried it: currently unavailable in his location
- No further knowledge beyond the name

Willingness to Change Behavior

- No strong platform loyalty; will switch if price and quality signals are right
- Quality perception is a concern with very low prices
 - Example: biryani at ₹100 raises doubts about quality
- Price is the primary switching trigger for this segment

Segment 2: Srivatsan Ramesh

Ordering Frequency and Preferences

- Orders very rarely: once a month or once every two months
- Has both Swiggy and Zomato installed
- Currently uses Zomato most frequently
 - Previously used Swiggy more; switched when Zomato’s offers started making more financial sense

Ordering Journey

- Always starts with a specific craving for a particular food type (e.g., pizza, paneer roll)

- Already knows which restaurant he wants before opening the app
 - Goes directly to that restaurant, looks for applicable offers, applies them, and pays
- Has clear restaurant preferences by food type:
 - Pizza: La Pino'z
 - Rolls: The Roll Company
- Triggers for ordering: cravings, not dissatisfaction with the mess or canteen

Price vs. Delivery Speed Tradeoff

- Default preference: lower price over faster delivery
 - "I would be OK with waiting for longer if the price is low"
- Exception: if in a hurry, will prioritize speed
- Comfortable with 40-50 minute delivery if the price is meaningfully lower

Pricing UI Comparison Reaction

- Shown the same two-app pricing comparison (same item, same restaurant)
- Chose App 1
 - Reason: familiar layout, transparent breakdown, comfortable with how charges were presented
 - "I'm used to something like everything" (familiar UI pattern)
- Agreed that App 1's pricing clarity would give it more traction than App 2

Awareness of Only/Ownly App

- Had not heard of it before the interview
- No prior exposure or awareness

Willingness to Change Behavior

- Expressed no desire to change current ordering behavior
 - "I am pretty happy with my ordering behavior right now"
- Low frequency means low urgency to optimize
 - Orders only when cravings arise; current apps satisfy that need adequately
- No stated pain points strong enough to motivate switching

User interview

Brand-blind cards · 15-minute conversation

Objective 1 — Current food-delivery behaviour

Q1

Tell me about the last food-delivery order you placed. Walk me through it.

"I opened Swiggy because I usually order from there. I don't really explore different apps every time. Most of the time, I go back to restaurants I've ordered from before and reorder something similar."

Insight: Repeat-order customer, not an app explorer.

Q2

What made you use that app instead of another one?

"I've been using Swiggy for a while, so I'm comfortable with it. I also have a subscription, and I use other things in the Swiggy ecosystem like Instamart. So everything is already there for me."

Insight: Loyalty is to the **ecosystem**, not food delivery alone.

Q3

Did you consider another app?

"Not really. I don't compare multiple apps every time. Sometimes I might check another app just to cross-check, but normally I use the same one."

Insight: Low active consideration of alternatives.

Q4

Was there anything at checkout you weren't expecting?

"I generally check the final amount. The extra fees are something I notice. I want to know what I'm actually paying before placing the order."

Insight: Sensitive to fee transparency. Notes do not establish that fees are the biggest pain.

Objective 2 — Real pain points

Q5

When was the last time a delivery order went badly?

"One time, I placed a late-night order on Zomato, but the order got cancelled. I checked Swiggy at the same time, but the same restaurant was showing as unavailable there too. So I couldn't order from that restaurant through another app."

Insight: The pain was **restaurant availability at late night**. When one platform cancelled, there was no fallback — the same restaurant was closed on the other app too.

Q6

What did you do about it?

"After the order was cancelled, I waited for the refund. I got the refund amount within a day, so the refund process was okay. But the bigger issue was that I couldn't reorder from the same restaurant because it wasn't available on Swiggy either."

Insight: The refund was fine (within a day). The stronger pain was **losing the restaurant after cancellation**, on a late-night order with few alternatives.

Q7

Did it change how you order?

"No, it didn't really change how I order. I still use the same apps and order from the restaurants I normally use."

Insight: The cancellation experience did not change the user's ordering behaviour. Despite the bad experience, existing habits and preferred restaurants remained unchanged.

Q8

Roughly how many bad orders before you stop using an app?

"It would have to happen repeatedly. One or two bad orders wouldn't make me stop using an app that I'm already comfortable with."

Insight: High switching tolerance. Habit and ecosystem create inertia.

Objective 3 — Price vs other benefits

Q9

Save ₹30, but take 15 minutes longer — which do you take?

"If I'm saving ₹30, I would wait an extra 15 minutes to save the money. But if I'm really hungry, I would prefer the faster delivery."

Insight: The user is willing to trade delivery time for savings, but urgency changes the decision. When hunger is high, faster delivery becomes more important than saving ₹30.

Q10

Save ₹30, but late 3 times in 10 instead of 1 in 10?

"If it is only sometimes late, I would still take the cheaper option because I'm saving money. But if it is regularly very late, then I wouldn't want that, especially when I'm hungry."

Insight: The user can tolerate some reduction in reliability when the saving is clear, but excessive or frequent delays become a deal-breaker when the order is urgent.

Q11

Save ₹30, but fewer of your usual restaurants?

“If the restaurant I want is available, I would choose the cheaper option. But if my usual restaurants aren’t available, then saving ₹30 doesn’t matter because I can’t order what I want.”

Insight: Price savings are attractive only when the service still provides access to the restaurants the user wants. Restaurant availability is a basic requirement for the saving to have value.

Q12

How much cheaper, every time, before you actually switched?

“It doesn’t necessarily have to be a huge amount. If I can consistently see that I’m saving money on my orders, I would consider switching. The saving should be enough to feel worthwhile compared with what I’m getting from my current app.”

Key insight: Consistent savings can motivate switching. The user is willing to trade some delivery speed or convenience for lower prices, provided the desired restaurants are available and the inconvenience is acceptable.

Objective 4 — Two cards, brand-blind

Q13

If only one of these existed where you live, which would you start using?

“I’d go with the first one — same food, smaller final bill. I want to know what I’m actually paying.”

Chose: Card 1 — smaller final bill, no extra platform / packaging fees. Not Card 2.

Q14 ★

Which line on that card made you pick it?

“The total you see is the total you pay — no platform fee, no packaging fee. That stood out.”

Key insight: He picked the **cleaner bill**, not “usual restaurants + on-time delivery.”

Q15

What's missing from the card you picked?

“If I see the complete breakdown — cart, GST, discount, delivery, platform, packaging — it adds friction. I might stop and rethink the order instead of just placing it.”

Key insight: Transparency has two sides. He wants **no surprise fees**, but a full itemised bill can **interrupt checkout and kill the order**. Show a smaller total. Don't make him sit through every line before he pays.

Q16

Do you think prices like that last, once an app gets popular?

“Probably not. An app may start with attractive prices, but once it becomes popular, I would expect the fees or prices to change.”

Insight: Skepticism toward promotional pricing. Ownly should not depend only on “we're cheaper right now.”

Objective 5 — Reveal: Ownly / Rapido

Q17

Had you heard of Ownly?

“No, I hadn't heard much about Ownly before.”

Insight: Unaware. Brand-blind section was not primed.

Q18

Does it being from Rapido change anything?

“Yes, to some extent. Since Rapido already has an ecosystem and I know the brand, that makes the service feel more familiar.”

Primary read: Trust. Known brand, expected to understand delivery and logistics.

Q18b

What's the first thing that comes to mind when you hear “from Rapido”?

“Rapido makes me think of bikes, transportation and getting things from one place to another.”

Insight: Familiarity helps. Bike-to-food still needs explaining.

Q19

Would you use Ownly again with no discount on the next three orders?

Not captured in this interview.

Record: Do not invent this answer. Ask it in the next interviews.

Q20

You haven't used it. What's actually stopping you?

“I haven't had a strong reason to change from Swiggy. I'm already comfortable with it and have my subscription and ecosystem there.”

Key insight: Barrier is not “I don't like Ownly.” It is “I don't have enough reason to leave my current app.”

Objective 6 — Actual switching behaviour

Q21

What would make you switch your main food app tomorrow?

"It would need to give me something significantly better — reliable delivery, the restaurants I already order from, and a better overall price. Just being slightly cheaper wouldn't be enough."

Q21b

Would you actually download and set everything up?

"If the difference was significant, maybe. But setting up another app is a hassle when everything is already configured in my current app."

Q21c

What's saved in your current app?

"My payment details, addresses, previous orders and restaurants I usually order from. I'd have to set all of that up again."

Switching cost = saved data + habit + ecosystem. A new app must beat: already configured → familiar restaurants → subscription → Instamart → habit.

Objective 7 — Close

Q22

What would you change about your current app?

"I'd want more predictable pricing and delivery. I don't want to see additional charges at the end, and I want the delivery time shown to be realistic."

Findings — this interview ownly

n = 1. Treat as a hypothesis. Do not report as “users think.”

Four pain points

- **Checkout friction** — a full fee breakdown can stop him mid-order
- **Surprise fees** — he still wants the final amount to be honest
- **Inertia** — everything is already set up on Swiggy
- **Reliability / restaurants** — late-night cancel with no fallback; same restaurant unavailable on the other app

What mattered here (hypothesis, not a ranking)

Need several more interviews before this order can be treated as a pattern.

Proposition to keep testing

Same food. Smaller final bill. The total on the button is the total you pay — without making checkout feel like homework.

Most important line from this interview

“If I see the complete breakdown, it adds friction. I might stop thinking about the order.”

He picked **Card 1**. He wants a cheaper, honest total — not a lecture of line items. Next interviews should check whether this repeats: **Does showing every fee help trust, or does it kill the order?**

Interview 2 — Price-sensitive frequent user

User interview: Food ordering app habits and pain points

User Profile

- Orders food around **10–15 times/month**
- Uses **Swiggy more frequently**, Zomato occasionally
- Usually orders during evenings and weekends

Ordering Priorities

- **Final price is the biggest factor**
- Delivery time is important, but willing to wait an extra 10–15 minutes for a meaningful saving
- Looks at the **total amount at checkout**, not individual delivery/platform fees
- Frequently changes restaurants based on available discounts
- Doesn't trust large discount banners until checking the final price

Awareness of New Apps

- Has seen advertisements for newer food-delivery apps
- Has downloaded one previously but stopped using it
- Main reason: **restaurants they wanted were not available**
- Would consider a new app if it had:
 - Better prices
 - Restaurants they already use
 - Good offers without complicated conditions
 - Reliable delivery

Pricing UI Preference

- Wants the **final payable amount to be extremely clear**
- Likes seeing:
 - Item total
 - Discount

- Delivery/platform charges
 - Final amount
- Doesn't want to calculate whether a coupon actually saved money
- Would prefer a simple message such as “**You save ₹85**”

Pain Points and Switching Triggers

- Feels that coupons often have too many conditions
- Gets frustrated when the price increases significantly at checkout
- Sometimes searches both apps before placing an order
- Discovery is mostly based on:
 - Previous orders
 - Ratings
 - Offers
 - Restaurant familiarity

Would switch if:

- A new app consistently offered **lower final prices**
 - Their favourite restaurants were available
 - Delivery was reliable
 - Friends started using and recommending it
 - There was no complicated coupon system
-

Interview 3 — Convenience and restaurant-quality focused user

User Profile

- Orders food around **6–8 times/month**
- Uses Swiggy primarily; Zomato as a backup
- Usually orders when busy with work/classes

Ordering Priorities

- **Convenience and reliability are more important than saving ₹20–30**
- Wants food to arrive within the promised time
- Restaurant quality matters significantly

- Doesn't spend much time browsing when hungry
- Usually opens the app and goes directly to:
 - Previous orders
 - Favourite restaurants
 - Search

Awareness of New Apps

- Has noticed advertisements for new food-delivery apps
- Hasn't tried them because **there is no strong reason to change**
- Existing apps already have:
 - Saved addresses
 - Order history
 - Favourite restaurants
 - Payment methods
- Doesn't want to spend time learning another app

Pricing UI Preference

- Doesn't care much about detailed fee breakdown
- Mainly wants to know:

“How much will I actually pay?”

- Doesn't want discounts to distract from ordering
- Would prefer the cheapest/most convenient option to be highlighted automatically

Pain Points and Switching Triggers

- Search sometimes gives too many irrelevant results
- Restaurant menus can be difficult to navigate
- Food quality doesn't always match ratings/photos
- Delivery estimates can be unreliable
- Biggest frustration is **receiving something different from what was ordered**

Would switch if:

- The new app had restaurants they already like
- Delivery reliability was demonstrably better
- Restaurant quality was trustworthy
- Friends or colleagues regularly used it
- Switching required almost **zero effort**

